

NON-LEAGUE

A season in the sixth tier

Twenty-two Saturdays. One squad. One bank account. An owner who wants something specific from you, and a dressing room that will not always agree.

A browser football-management game · Single HTML file · ~158 KB

It started as a wishlist

The original brief asked for every football game at once

Every club in the world

and every stadium walkable

Fifteen career paths

footballer, referee, kit designer,
agent

Hundreds of attributes

per player, visible and hidden

AI that learns

with no scripted behaviour

A design that says yes to everything has made no decisions.

Licensing walls, contradictory pillars, and no answer to the only question that matters: what are you doing minute to minute?

What survived

One spine, chosen deliberately

CUT

- The open world — a commute is not gameplay
- Real licences — unobtainable at any budget
- Fourteen of the fifteen career paths
- Machine-learning opponents
- Hundreds of attributes

KEPT

- + You run a sixth-tier club for 22 weeks
- + Eighteen players you know by name
- + A live match you stand through
- + Money that runs out
- + Consequences that persist

Depth comes from a few variables interacting richly, not a long list. Chess has six piece types.

The weekly loop

Four stages, repeated twenty-two times



Nothing resets between weeks. A knackered squad in week 9 is a knackered squad in week 10.

Training: three slots, eight options

Every session costs something you also want

SESSION	ABILITY	FITNESS	ELSE
Drills	+1.50 ability	-8 fitness	-2 morale
Recovery	—	+13 fitness	+1 morale
Team night	—	+2 fitness	+7 morale · +5 mood
Community day	-0.30 ability	-1 fitness	+£3,000
Video session	+0.35 ability	+1 fitness	reliable scouting
Strength work	+0.20 ability	-4 fitness	fewer knocks
Penalty box	+0.10 ability	-1 fitness	better from 12 yards
Clear the air	-0.20 ability	+4 fitness	+12 dressing room

The tension

Sharpness costs legs. Legs cost points. Points buy you time with the board.

Train flat out and you are sacked 28% of the time. Never train and the division improves past you.

There is no free lunch and no dominant strategy.

Eighteen players, not three bars

Each one is a small system

Ability

What he can do. Grows slowly with training.

Fitness

Where his legs are today. Carries over from Saturday.

Form

A rolling rating. Good games beget good games.

Mood

Falls when he does not play. Ends in a transfer request.

Trait

Engine, Flair, Leader, Fragile, Poacher, Wall, Hothead, Ice, Shot-stopper.

Personality

Professional, Firebrand, Joker, Loner, Big-time.

Matchday rating = ability, scaled by fitness and mood. A sharp exhausted squad is worth less than a fresh mediocre one.

Four decisions before kick-off

Each one is legible and each one is a trade

SHAPE

Five formations

3-5-2 owns midfield and leaks behind. 5-3-2 digs a trench.

THE ELEVEN

Picked by hand

Fitness, form, mood and traits all visible. Play the tired star or do not.

HOW WE PLAY

Four tactics

Press beats possession beats block beats direct beats press.

THE TALK

Five options

Fire them up lifts a confident squad and wounds a fragile one.

A scouting report tells you how they usually play — right about 75% of the time, or reliably if you did the video work.

The match runs without you

until it needs you

SIXTEEN BEATS

6' 12' 18' 24' 30' 36' 42' 45'
50' 56' 62' 68' 74' 80' 86' 90'

Each beat rolls chances for both sides from the current strength differential, then updates momentum, fatigue, cards and injuries.

Speeds: 1× · 2× · skip

LIVE READOUT

- Score and clock
- Momentum bar, swinging both ways
- Possession, shots, on target, corners
- Commentary that names your players
- Substitutions available at any moment

Three substitutions. Positions need not match — you will feel it if they do not.

The calls you make at 3pm

Triggered by the state of the game, not a script

HALF - TIME

Always fires

Calm heads · rip into them · change shape ·
make a change

CHASING IT

62' and behind

Throw a forward on · push the line up · stay
patient

SEEING IT OUT

72' and ahead

Shut up shop · keep going · waste time and risk
cards

UNDER SIEGE

Momentum collapse

Drop deeper · ride it out · go after them

A MAN DOWN

Knock or booking

Take him off · strap him up · gamble on the
referee

LAST MAN

Striker through

Haul him down for a red · let him go

Three ways a penalty happens

The moment the room goes quiet

1

YOU WIN ONE

Pick your taker from three, with composure ratings shown. The Ice trait is worth 20 points. Penalty practice raises everyone.

2

YOU CONCEDE ONE

Dive left, dive right, or stand up. Video analysis gives you a hint on their taker — right about 80% of the time.

3

LAST MAN

Their striker is clean through. Haul him down for a red card and a penalty, or let him go and take your chances.

Roughly six penalties a season. Rare enough to matter, common enough to have practised for.

Buying and selling

Two windows, real wages, and a squad floor of twelve

WINDOWS

Weeks 1–4

Weeks 12–15

A fresh five-man shortlist each week the window is open. Ages, wages, traits and personalities all shown.

SELLING

65%

of value if you sell now. Wait for an unsolicited bid and you get the lot — if one ever comes.

Selling a happy player costs you dressing-room mood.

THE WAGE BILL

Every Friday

The sum of your squad, deducted weekly. A signing is a commitment for the rest of the season, not a purchase.

Below -£20,000 the club enters administration.

The academy: you cannot see what you have

12

Scouting is the product you are actually buying

WHAT THE GAME SHOWS YOU

Rio Ridgeway FWD 15y

Now 29 Ceiling 52-78

True ceiling: 64. You are never told this.

Four facility tiers narrow that band from ± 26 to exact. £5,500 to £27,000.

A typical academy season produces a graduate around 71 ability with 22 appearances — no fee, low wage, better than most of the market.

COACHING

Free to £640/wk

×1.00 to ×2.20 development

FACILITIES

£0 to £27,000

×1.00 to ×1.62, plus scouting and places

THEY MULTIPLY

×2.2 combined

A season becomes a different player

PROMOTE AT 40

Keeps growing

Faster still if he is actually playing

Off the field

Private lives that arrive at training whether you ask or not

EIGHT HABITS

Up all night gaming · Lives in the gym · Doing a degree · Likes a bet ·
Young kids at home · Running a side business · Out most weekends
· Quiet life

Each one moves fitness and mood every week — and decides which
crises land on your desk.

RELATIONSHIP STRAIN

Rises when he is unhappy
Rises faster when he is not picked
Rises for the socialite and the gambler
Falls for the quiet ones and the fathers

This is a feedback loop, not decoration. Leave a man out for six weeks
and you damage his form, his relationship, and then his form again.

Thirty-four events, all conditional

They only fire when your situation invites them

The exes

One player finds out his partner used to go out with a teammate. From a photograph. On the team bus.

The split

Only when strain is already critical. Give him a week off, or tell him football is the best thing for him.

Two hundred miles

Her job offer. Pay him more, tell him to go, or ask him to see the season out.

The bust-up

Two players pulled apart in training. Fine both, back one, or let them sort it out.

The chairman

Only fires when board faith is low. Take responsibility, blame the budget, or ask for time.

The banner

Three defeats in four and three hundred supporters stay behind. Go and talk to them, or say nothing.

Five owners, five different games

The same decisions, judged by a different rule

THE FANATIC

Terry Coyne

Top three. Nothing else remembered.

£18k · £2,000 a win

Hardest

THE CONSORTIUM

Northgate Capital

Return the capital. Stay up.

£45k · £1,800/wk

Hard

THE CUSTODIANS

Supporters' Trust

No debt. Happy squad. Top half.

£22k · £400/wk

Forgiving

THE EX-PRO

Danny Kerrigan

Blood three kids. One graduate.

£28k · £600/wk

Testing

THE ABSENTEE

A company in Jersey

Give back what he put in.

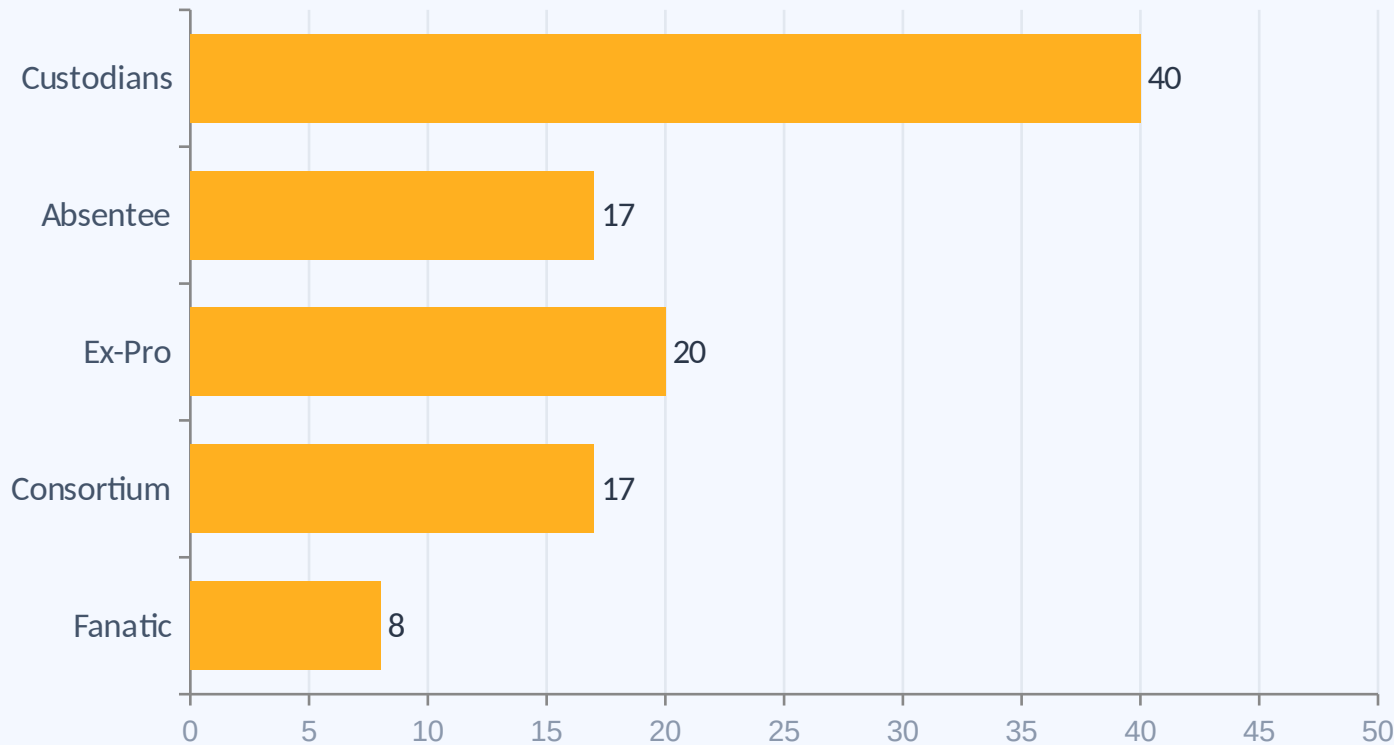
£12k · -£900/wk

Testing

Selling your best striker is a betrayal under one owner and prudent asset management under another.

Proof the owners are different

250 simulated seasons, identical play, five owners



What this told me

The same season produces a triumph under one owner and a sacking under another.

That spread is the design working. It also gave me a difficulty ladder, so the setup screen now labels the Trust "start here".

Without the simulation I would have shipped five owners that all felt like the same job.

Balancing without playtesters

Every system was tested headlessly before it shipped

2,000+

seasons simulated

4

playing styles compared

0

dominant strategies found

Train flat out

sacked in 28% of seasons — exhaustion is fatal

Never train

safe mid-table while the division improves past you

Counter the scouting report

roughly triples the promotion rate

Invest in the academy

breaks even within one season, wins beyond it

Rivalries the game did not write

Heat accumulates from what actually happens

Heavy defeat

+9

A red card

+11

Late winner

+7

Bad-tempered game

+4

Neck and neck

+5

Any meeting

+4

What heat does

Bigger crowd and gate · doubled morale swing on the result · more cards for both sides · amplified board reaction · its own commentary

It decays if you leave it alone. One club starts as your historic derby; the rest you earn.

How it is built

One file, no build step, no dependencies

158 KB

a single HTML file

0

npm packages

0

network requests at runtime

~3,400

lines of JavaScript

Rendering

Full re-render per state change. No framework, no virtual DOM, no reconciliation to debug.

Interface

Seven tabs, a live match view, an SVG pitch, and a rolling-football cursor with a comet trail.

Theming

Your kit colour is a CSS custom property. Pick violet and the entire interface repaints.

Testing

The game logic runs headlessly under mock DOM objects, so simulations test the shipped code.

The principle

Every system had to change a decision

Not add a number, not add a screen. If a feature did not make you weigh something you were not weighing before, it did not go in — and if it stopped doing that, it came back out.

The wishlist wanted everything. The game is what was left after saying no.